

# Facilitator Self-Care Guide

\*You cannot pour from an empty cup. Peer support work is emotionally demanding — taking care of yourself isn't optional, it's part of the job.\*

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## Know the signs of compassion fatigue

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If you're experiencing several of these, it's time to adjust:

- **Irritability** — small things feel like big things
- **Numbness** — you stop feeling moved by others' stories
- **Avoidance** — you dread sessions or find reasons to cancel
- **Intrusive thoughts** — carrying participants' stories home with you
- **Physical symptoms** — headaches, sleep changes, fatigue
- **Cynicism** — "nothing ever changes anyway"

## Boundaries to set

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### With participants

- Sessions start and end on time
- You are not available between sessions (except for emergencies with a clear plan)
- You share your own experiences intentionally, not reactively
- You refer out when someone needs professional therapy or case management

### With yourself

- You do not answer emails or messages about the group outside of working hours
- You keep a separate journal for your own processing (not session notes)
- You have at least one person you can talk to about the work (supervisor, peer, therapist)

### With your co-facilitator

- Debrief after every session — 10 minutes minimum
- Check in on each other: "How are you holding up?"
- Have a signal for "I need you to take the lead right now"
- Rotate difficult tasks (crisis follow-ups, intake calls)

## Daily practices

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### Before a session

- ☐ 5 minutes of quiet or grounding
- ☐ Review the session plan
- ☐ Check in with your co-facilitator
- ☐ Set an intention ("I will listen without trying to fix")

### After a session

- ☐ Write session notes (within 24 hours)
- ☐ Do a brief transition ritual (short walk, drink of water, change of clothes)
- ☐ Debrief with co-facilitator
- ☐ Let go of what is not yours to carry

### Weekly

- ☐ Review the week's sessions — any themes you're carrying?
- ☐ One activity that has nothing to do with peer support
- ☐ Connect with someone who understands the work

## When to step back

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- You dread sessions for more than two weeks
- Your own mental health is declining
- You're showing up but not present
- A participant's story is triggering your own unprocessed experience
- Someone you trust tells you they're worried about you

**Stepping back is not failure.** It is the most responsible thing you can do for yourself and the people you support.

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\*This guide is informed by the work of Laurie Anne Pearlman, Charles Figley, and the Center for Victims of Torture's self-care resources.\*

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